has also resisted the sect's attempt to put the Swaminarayan deity on par with Hindu deities. Back in 1948, in an alleged attempt to stop Dalits from entering their temples, the Swaminarayan sect had submitted that its premises did not fall under the ambit of the Bombay Harijan Temple Entry Act, 1947, and, later on, the Bombay Hindu Places of Public Worship (Entry Authorisation) Act, 1956, as they were not connected to the Hindu religion.

Cut to September 2023 and a huge controversy erupted when a mural depicting Hanuman sitting at the feet of Swaminarayan appeared on the premises of the Kashtabhanjandev Hanuman Mandir in Salangpur village in Botad, Gujarat. The murals were defaced and the Vishwa Hindu Parishad led the charge of several communities, including the Sharada Peeth Dwarka Shankaracharya Swami Sadanand Saraswati Maharaj, in calling for a ban on the Swaminarayan sect. The controversy was contained with the sect removing the offending murals. Bansal, however, claims all that is past, and says the Salangpur shrine was not even a BAPS temple.

More seriously, in 2021, some of the workers at the Robbinsville temple filed a class action lawsuit against BAPS in the US for paying them less than minimum wages. The organisation was also accused of violating immigration and labour laws. The FBI had visited the temple and taken 110 of the 134 artisans working there into protective custody. BAPS has denied any wrongdoing. Bansal is quick to highlight a statement put out by 12 of the workers (in July 2023) saying they were forced to make these allegations in lieu of money and US citizenship.

Meanwhile, BAPS will be hoping that with the largest temple in the Arab countries, its efforts to emerge as the global face of Sanatana Dharma gets a major boost. The sect seems to have the backing of Prime Minister Modi, but it remains to be seen whether the wider Hindu community in the region embraces the grand temple. ■

